Chapter Two

The Crusader Enemy

Between 1100 and 1138,
the emperor of Constantinople and the Crusaders
fight against each other

Alexius Comnenus, the Christian emperor of Constantinople, had distrusted the Crusaders from the beginning.

As each German and Italian and Frankish nobleman arrived in Constantinople with his own private army, ready to cross over the Bosphorus Strait and face the enemy, Alexius had demanded a sacred oath. Whatever "cities, countries or forces he might in future subdue . . . he would hand over to the officer appointed by the emperor." They were, after all, there to fight for Christendom; and Alexius Comnenus was the ruler of Christendom in the east.[1]

Just as Alexius had feared, the chance to build private kingdoms in the Holy Land proved too tempting.

The first knight to bite the apple was the Norman soldier Bohemund, who had arrived in Constantinople at the start of the First Crusade and immediately became one of the foremost commanders of the Crusader armies. Spearheading the capture of the great city Antioch in 1098, Bohemund at once named himself its prince and flatly refused to honor his oath. ("Bohemund," remarked Alexius's daughter and biographer, Anna, "was by nature a liar.") By 1100, Antioch had been joined by two other Crusader